

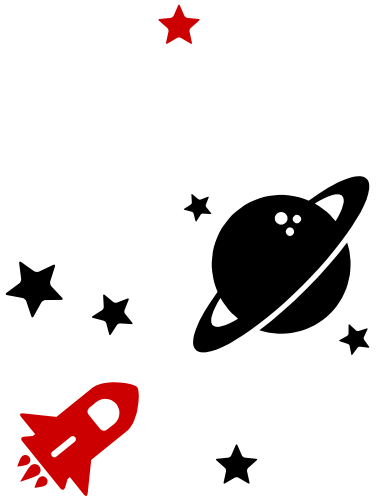
AUDIENCE TYPES

STW EX20003
Unit 01

AUDIENCE

Intended or potential reader/ listener/ viewer

Technical writing is adapted to meet needs, interests, level of understanding, and background of audience



AUDIENCE TYPES & IDENTIFICATION



TYPE	DESCRIPTION
EXPERTS	People who know the business, the organization and the product i. e. they have advanced knowledge They often operate in academic settings or in R&D areas of the government and technology worlds
TECHNICIANS	People who build, operate, maintain, and repair the items that the experts design i. e. they too have advanced knowledge They have highly technical knowledge of a more practical nature (hands-on)
EXECUTIVES	People who make business, economic, administrative, legal, governmental, or political decisions about the products (buy or no-buy decisions) They may or may not have technical knowledge about the subject They are usually the primary audience for documents such as proposals and reports (the CEOs, committees, hiring managers)



TYPE	DESCRIPTION
GATEKEEPERS	People who oversee the writer and the document They decide if the document is compliant with rules, regulations, company policies, legal obligations, and purpose for the client
NON-SPECIALISTS or LAYPEOPLE	People with the least technical knowledge of the topic i. e. employees/ students from other fields They want to use the new product to accomplish tasks They need to understand the new technology, products, or procedures enough to use them in a particular situation
MIXED AUDIENCE	Combination of audience types and backgrounds Wide variability within audience, and/ or unknown audience



AUDIENCE IDENTIFICATION

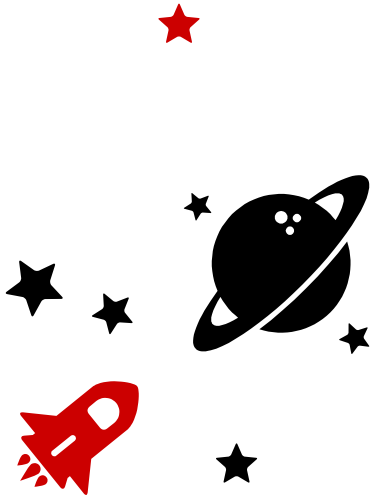
- **Primary Audience:** action takers or target audience i. e. the information/ instruction provided helps them to do something or make a decision
- **Secondary Audience:** advisors i. e. experts in the field/ topic with in-depth knowledge with which they can advise the primary audience and help them to make a decision; also check for legal implications etc.
- **Tertiary Audience:** evaluators i. e. assessors of the content created or provided; potential viewers with a related focus to the content (people who are removed from the situation but may have cause to read the document at some point)

[Definitions from *Technical Communication Today* by Richard Johnson-Sheehan]



AUDIENCE IDENTIFICATION

- For example, in a blog about Ruby programming language for early-career Ruby developers, consisting of tutorials, reference guides, and how-to blog posts that explain Ruby concepts, audiences might look like this:
- **Primary Audience:** Early-career Ruby developers with 0-2 years of Ruby programming experience
- **Secondary Audience**: Advanced Ruby developers who want to share beginner-level content with their students, **OR** open source maintainers who want to understand what concepts are most important to beginners
- **Tertiary Audience:** Hiring managers or podcast producers who are curious about blog content, writing style, and areas of specialization in advance of an interview



THAT'S ALL, FOLKS!